

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Media and Entertainment English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For producers, production managers, creative executives, rights coordinators, distribution teams, talent managers, marketing staff, and media operations professionals.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Development notes

02 Production schedule squeeze

03 Music clearance

04 Talent approval

05 Distribution window

06 Audience readout

07 Sponsor integration

08 Holding statement

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Development notes

A producer and editor refine a story opening.

Roles: Producer / Story editor

Producer: The opening has energy, but I don't understand what the lead character wants.

Story editor: We reveal that in scene four. Would moving the decision earlier help?

Producer: Yes. Can we establish the objective without adding an explanatory monologue?

Story editor: I'll try an action-led version and preserve the information needed for the later reveal.

Producer: Bring both versions so we can compare pacing and clarity.

Story editor: I'll annotate what changes in the sequence rather than treat every note as a request for more dialogue.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We reveal that in scene four. Would moving the decision earlier help?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Production schedule squeeze

A production team adjusts for an unavailable location.

Roles: Production manager / First assistant director

Production manager: The warehouse location is unavailable on Tuesday. Can we swap the exterior scenes into that day?

First assistant director: Only after checking cast, daylight, permits, equipment, and travel between setups.

Production manager: I'll confirm location and supplier availability for the alternatives.

First assistant director: I'll build a revised stripboard and assess the effect on the shooting day.

Production manager: Keep additional costs visible before we approve the move.

First assistant director: Once the plan is approved, we'll issue an updated call sheet and ensure everyone receives it.

Notice the professional language

call sheet - A production document listing who is needed, where, and when for a shoot.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Music clearance

A team reviews a song used in a rough cut.

Roles: Editor / Rights coordinator

Editor: The director loves this track. Are we cleared to use it in the online trailer?

Rights coordinator: We need to verify the required rights, territories, term, and permitted media for that use.

Editor: The project has a license for festival screenings. Is that enough?

Rights coordinator: Don't assume it covers the trailer. I'll check the actual agreement and clearance requirements.

Editor: I'll keep it marked as temporary in the edit notes.

Rights coordinator: I'll confirm the permitted use or bring alternatives before the trailer is released.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The director loves this track. Are we cleared to use it in the online trailer?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Talent approval

A campaign team prepares a talent-related image.

Roles: Talent manager / Creative producer

Talent manager: This still is scheduled for publication, but the talent approval is still pending.

Creative producer: The creative team thought approval of the shoot covered all selections.

Talent manager: We need to follow the actual contractual approval process, including this use.

Creative producer: I'll pause the scheduled asset and provide the required context for review.

Talent manager: I'll track the response and any revisions requested.

Creative producer: Once approval is documented, I'll release the correct version to distribution.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "This still is scheduled for publication, but the talent approval is still pending." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Distribution window

A distributor asks about an early streaming release.

Roles: Distribution manager / Rights executive

Distribution manager: The platform wants to launch two weeks early. Does that conflict with another window?

Rights executive: We need to check the territory, exclusivity period, and existing commitments.

Distribution manager: The proposed date differs by market, so I'll supply a territory-by-territory schedule.

Rights executive: Good. A general approval wouldn't resolve those differences.

Distribution manager: I'll keep the platform date tentative until rights review is complete.

Rights executive: I'll identify permitted options and any consent needed before we change the release plan.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The platform wants to launch two weeks early. Does that conflict with another window?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Audience readout

A team compares two shows' performance.

Roles: Audience analyst / Commissioning editor

Audience analyst: The new show has more starts, but a lower completion rate.

Commissioning editor: Are the episodes comparable in length and the audiences at the same point in the release cycle?

Audience analyst: Not yet. The older show has had longer to accumulate viewing.

Commissioning editor: Then normalize the comparison period and explain the metric definitions.

Audience analyst: I'll also separate unique viewers, starts, and completed episodes.

Commissioning editor: Bring that view before we decide whether the opening or the distribution strategy needs attention.

Notice the professional language

completion rate - The proportion of started or eligible activities that reach a defined end point.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Sponsor integration

A producer reviews a sponsor's late request.

Roles: Branded-content producer / Editorial lead

Branded-content producer: The sponsor wants the presenter to call the product the market leader.

Editorial lead: What evidence supports that claim, and has it passed the required review?

Branded-content producer: They haven't supplied the basis. We can describe a verified feature instead.

Editorial lead: Also check the disclosure and placement requirements for the integration.

Branded-content producer: I'll propose revised wording and send it through approval.

Editorial lead: Preserve the agreed editorial boundaries and make sure the final cut matches the approved version.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What evidence supports that claim, and has it passed the required review?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Holding statement

A communications team prepares a response during a controversy.

Roles: Communications director / Production executive

Communications director: Reporters are asking about an incident, but several details are still unverified.

Production executive: We should state only what we can confirm and identify who is reviewing the matter.

Communications director: I'll avoid naming individuals or speculating about responsibility.

Production executive: Coordinate the wording with the relevant legal and safeguarding reviewers where applicable.

Communications director: I'll prepare a factual holding statement and a process for incoming questions.

Production executive: We'll update it when verified information changes, keeping the approval and version history clear.

Notice the professional language

holding statement - An initial public message stating verified information while further facts are being established.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Creative Briefs and Development Notes

SHARED CASE

A client asks for a video to feel "premium and energetic." The team has no examples, audience definition, or delivery requirements.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you share a reference and explain which qualities you want to capture? Let's also confirm the audience and deliverables so the creative direction can be discussed concretely.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Production Planning and Budget

SHARED CASE

A production schedule adds a location change, but transport time and the budget have not been revised.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The location change adds work that is not reflected in the current schedule or budget. I'll identify the transport and setup implications for review before we confirm the revised plan.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Rights, Clearances, and Licensing

SHARED CASE

A draft video includes music with unclear licensing documentation. The planned channels and territories are known.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could the rights team confirm that the license covers the planned channels and territories? I'll provide the intended use and asset details so the clearance question can be reviewed before publication.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Talent, Contracts, and Approvals

SHARED CASE

A talent agreement includes an approval step, but the production calendar does not show who submits material or when.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Who submits the material for approval, what is being reviewed, and what timing does the agreement specify? Let's put those responsibilities into the production schedule.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Distribution and Windowing

SHARED CASE

Two distribution proposals offer different exclusivity periods and territories. A summary compares only the fee.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The fee is only one difference. We should compare the rights window, territory, exclusivity, and other terms before describing one proposal as more valuable.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Audience Metrics and Performance

SHARED CASE

A campaign video reaches more viewers but has a lower completion rate. A report labels it an unqualified success.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Reach increased, while completion rate declined. I'll relate each measure to the campaign objective and avoid treating one headline number as the full performance story.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Sponsorship, Brand Safety, and Integration

SHARED CASE

A sponsor requests an additional product mention after the integration plan has been agreed.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can review the request against the agreed deliverables and editorial requirements. Could we clarify the exact change and its implications before confirming that it is included?

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Crisis Response and Public Statements

SHARED CASE

A draft public statement gives an explanation for a production incident while facts are still being verified.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

We should state only what has been confirmed, acknowledge the concern, and explain the next information step. The proposed cause is still unverified and needs appropriate review before inclusion.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.